

Oblique Mirrors and Specular Trickery

In a tale from the end of the sixteenth century, the author Étienne Tabourot mocks the simpleness and ignorance of a poor man, incapable of distinguishing reality from its representation or reflection. This man placed a mirror at the end of his bed “to see if he looked well as he slept.”¹ This comical anecdote has a serious side: the mirror hides something absolutely essential, the face of the man sleeping. This is the limit of the experience of the mirror—the impossibility of seeing oneself with eyes closed, or the impossibility, even with the artifice of several mirrors, of meeting a darting glance. At this unreachable point, this void, everything that escapes comes creeping back and is reconstituted as a whole—the unknown part of the self. Shielded from consciousness, this invisible presence is sensed by each of us.

It happens that this emptiness etches its fleeting trail on the mirror. Who hasn’t been surprised at least once by seeing his reflection in a mirror he happened across? This “strange and merciless” mirror Proust spoke of, describing his room at Balbec, eyed him with hostility and “obliquely close[d] off” the room.² His emotion is evidence that the encounter with the mirror touched a sensitive nerve by capturing the inexpressible in a fraction of a moment. Once the awkwardness has passed, the image is reconstituted, identical and familiar, and the anxiety

dissipates. The famous text in which Freud recounts how he thought he saw a stranger enter his train compartment just as a violent jolt suddenly opened the door to the lavatory has familiarized us with this “uncanny” feeling, the face of the intruder, not of an other, but of the other in one’s self: “I hurried to help him, but was quickly taken aback when I realized that the intruder was none other than my own image reflected in the mirror of the connecting door. And I remember that this apparition gave me profound displeasure.”³ If Socrates’s mirror is the instrument of self-construction, the revelation of otherness occurs in the flash of the chance reflection and the sideways glance. It is in the unexpected encounter or brief trespass in which the unknown self emerges. In the sudden interruption and in dissonance, what is missing or repressed carves out its disconcerting face.

The Mirror and Alterity

Sideways Glances

In order to get the mirror to admit to its falsehoods, the onlooker must not fall prey to its steady, straightforward reflection. Just as an echo abbreviates and alters the direction of a sound, the reflection caught in the corner of the eye offers an alternate path of vision, revealing new angles while at the same time ensuring a kind of symmetry, albeit an imperfect one. The object and its reflection cannot be superimposed onto each other since in the mirror the left hand becomes the right hand. A dissemblance slips into duplication, and maybe some duplicity as well. The comments on the mirror of the Italian humanist and architect Leon Battista Alberti (1404–1472) in his *Della Pittura* [*On Painting*] (1436) are well known: “I do not know how it happens that painted objects have grace in the mirror; it is a wonderful thing to see how any fault appears deformed in the mirror.”⁴ The reflection creates a

tiny gap in the heart of resemblance; it adds grace, this *je ne sais quoi* of beauty, irreducible to the rule of proportions. Its unsymmetrical qualities overpower the ugly and border on the monstrous. In order for there to be congruence, there would have to be a series of mirrors in which the object and the image of its image would coincide, but with this arrangement, the distortion caused by this optical assembly would cause the image to lose any link to reality. By simulating resemblance, the mirror dissimulates another truth, one that can emerge only surreptitiously, in a fearsome difference and obliquity: “dubious resemblance” or troubling strangeness, the mirror is a mirror of otherness.

“Likeness does not make things ‘one’ as much as unlikeness makes them ‘other.’”⁵ As much as the efforts of classical psychology, from Aristotle to the seventeenth century, sought a stable and like image of the individual in the inventory of his humors and the observation of his physiognomy, they were able to shed light only on the traits of the universal man in his generality and abstraction. It took the imagination of the artist, the intuition of certain spiritual people, the very oblique gaze of Montaigne to discover the hidden profile. It was by renouncing the reproduction, by refusing the frontal, fixed mirror (the verifier of identity) that singularity affirmed itself.

It is in “the great mirror of the world,” that Montaigne observes himself, not in an attempt at introspection, but obliquely, in the reflection of circumstances and occasions: “I do not find myself where I look for myself, and find myself more often by accident than through the exercise of my reason.”⁶ The self-portrait does not attempt to grasp something within or repressed waiting to be revealed; rather, it is slowly developed from a fortuitous encounter between two “selves,” the familiar face and the unknown one that unexpectedly bursts forth. In the same way, “the sun and wind beat down more heavily on us when deflected than when they come down directly.”⁷ Obliquity is feared because it takes one by surprise, as a thief does, and its “larceny” reveals a hidden truth.

blazing rays of the sun. The magical mirror is thus the mirror of efficacious desire. This theme was already present in the poetry of the Middle Ages (as in the fourteenth-century work of Jean Froissart, who, for example, gives a lover a mirror, a reservoir of all possible images) and runs throughout the following centuries of romantic literature.²⁵

Games of the Mirror and of Love

The mirror mediates between the dream and the real. It offers a virtual space for the encounter with the other—a fictive space in which an imaginary scenario is played out. It can be the mirror of the shy person, of the voyeur, or even of the spy: those who observe with the aid of a mirror a secret that is not meant for them. The frontal encounter is eluded or deferred, while the mirror frees up a margin of interpretation in the face of a truth that cannot be told face to face. It can also be the seductive mirror of catoptric games; the luminous and reflecting surface tames the strange and transfigures the scene in order to adorn it with a grace and beauty that the real does not have.

The reflection de-realizes the spectacle, and through it, desire is given the legitimacy to express itself since it no longer fears the sanction of the real. It creates a truth unburdened by the weight of its consequences. Critic Jean Starobinski has said it all about the scene in which Rousseau surprises Madame Basile, his hostess, at the half-open door (*Confessions*, L.2).²⁶ Believing himself to be sheltered from her gaze, he falls to his knees at the entrance to her room, “holding out my arms in a passionate embrace, well sure that she couldn’t hear me and not thinking that she could see me. But there above the fireplace was a mirror that betrayed me. She hardly looked at me, hardly spoke to me, but turning her head halfway, with one simple finger, she showed me the braid at her feet.” On the lover’s journey to his beloved, the mirror serves both timid and exhibitionist tendencies. The joy of seeing without being seen is replaced by the thrill of being discovered peeking. Once

they have found refuge in the imaginary field of the reflection, Rousseau and Madame Basile can love each other guiltlessly.

Starobinski confers the status of archetype on this short scene, because it is useful for representing the act of writing itself. The *Confessions* are certainly this oblique reflection by which Rousseau watches himself and reveals himself with impunity, with an immodesty that takes the reader as its accomplice just as Madame Basile had consented to the role that her partner assigned her and allowed herself to be stared at in the mirror, renouncing all Medusa-like power of petrification and punishment. The *Confessions* are meant to exorcise, or to seduce, the face of the Medusa that a “virtuous self” represses—Perseus triumphs obliquely. Afterward, the fatal trophy, represented on the shield or aegis, makes its holder invincible because it deflects the impulses of those who wish to judge him.

Stendhal, particularly sensitive to the mediating powers of the mirror that the novelist carries along with him in his wanderings, said that, in certain cities of Prussia, all of the distinguished houses have near their windows mirrors a foot high attached to an iron stand and inclined toward the interior.²⁷ Thanks to these mirrors, young women observe their suitors in the street, but the suitors cannot see the interior of the apartment — nor that of the heart. Here the mirror is an instrument of dissimulation and of an oblique power: while the lover abandons himself to the gaze of the young girl and accepts his subjection, she exercises the only right conceded to her by society, that of indirectly observing, without lowering her eyes. The mirror confers impunity on the one who sees and on the one who is seen, but only reciprocity and the exchange of glances can stabilize the image.

It is this perfect reciprocity, in which the love of self and the love of the other intersect, and where fantasy joins the real in the fulfillment of desire that Goethe presented before us in his *Wilhelm Meister's Travels*. The catoptric novelistic exploitation that writers made of “mirror staging” is well known. It was aimed at expanding a narrative by grafting a second narrative onto it.

The mirror, at once metaphor and object, carves out a potential space and imposes a shift in time that function as a parenthetical aside. The mirror calls forth time, space, and the imaginary, and thus plays the role of projecting an “other” truth, a truth which the characters have not understood or of which they are unaware.²⁸

This is how Goethe uses it, inserting a short story on the theme of the mirror within his *Wilhelm Meister's Travels*. Two young people, Lucidor and Lucinde—two mirror names—discover that they love each other, and before abandoning themselves in an embrace, Lucidor frees himself from Lucinde's arms and pulls her before a mirror: “Then he saw her in his arms and saw himself wrapped in hers; he lowered his eyes and then raised them again and again.”²⁹ Reality and the world of fantasy meet in the mirror, intensifying the gestures of love and trumping reality, each lover drawing happiness from the spectacle of the other. But the goal of the writer is even more to illuminate a trivial little love story by the grace of the reflection. All of the narrative takes place in effect under the magic of the large mirror placed in the entryway of the house, a mirror reflecting the love scene onto an immense backdrop of wooded countryside: “No one could grow tired of turning from the mirror toward nature and from nature toward the mirror.” The telescopic mirror, reverberating the distances beneath the rays of the sun, is useful as a metaphor for the passage from the tangible world to the poetic one: it encourages the couple to not remain prisoners of narcissistic love and the comfort of the home, and, as an emblem for the whole work, it offers a cosmic tableau whereby the union of man and nature is sealed.

Playing with Monsters

The Seduction of the Anamorphosis

By attempting to surprise the alterity of desire and love in the oblique mirror, however, one risks setting the deceptive forces of

the imagination in motion and causing the unexpected to appear—one's own face disfigured by emotions, passion, and repression. How can one know that the mirror won't reflect some horrifying trait? The oblique mirror disconcerts; it is sly and deviant. Therefore, rather than allow himself to be taken by surprise, the man who masters optical games prefers to organize the spectacle himself, to make strangeness trivial and to trap this fear of mirrors (specular fear) by diverting its insidious or seductive effects onto the other.

Fioravanti, the sixteenth-century alchemist, who devoted several pages of his *Miroir des arts et des sciences* to the miraculous workings of mirrors, tells of Italian princes and noblemen who decorated their palaces with mirrors in order to better enjoy the distress of their guests: "I remember having seen once in Naples a knight with a mirror made with such ingenuity that when a person would present himself before it, that person would see more than a dozen figures or shadows come out of it, terrifying those looking into it."³⁰ With their illusions and shimmering surfaces, mirror games offered endless possibilities for producing bizarre and distorted images and for taming monsters: the mystifying powers of reflections were thus deliberately sought, exploited, and implored with willing fascination.

To represent a monster is to tame him. Leonardo da Vinci enjoyed creating monstrous forms and constructing optical chambers in which the disturbances of the images and the explosions of space lent themselves to dreaming. Like the painter, the Renaissance scientist took pleasure in multiplying experiments of this "natural magic" of optical manipulations. Cardano devoted fourteen chapters of his treatise to the miracles of catoptrics, describing in precise detail the types of mirrors that make it possible to invert, multiply, make distant, draw near, or fragment an object in space. A man can be made to appear to fly in the air, appear upside down, or become suddenly obese. His nose or hand can be isolated and distant parts can be joined "so

that a monstrous spectacle will appear before you.”³¹ One can also “see in secret, without alarming anyone, what is happening afar.” Horror before the monstrous is transformed into exultation, which is not wholly exempt from fright because it consists of a secret, and thus provides guilty pleasures: those of surreptitiously wielding hidden information, being found out, and manipulating others.

Anamorphosis, a calculated distortion characterized by art critic Jurgis Baltrušaitis in his study of anamorphic art as “a rebus of monster and marvel,” relies on a subversion of the image and a “teratology of perspective.”³² By substituting the reflected angle in place of the visual angle, by adding a lateral point of view to a frontal one, anamorphosis breaks up the coherence of space: seen from a certain angle, a portrait is only pieces—deformity, dislocation—but from another, unity is reconstituted and the initiated spectator recognizes the laws of a rigorous science behind the optical aberrations. On account of these laws, confusion and the irrational are resolved.

These games that deconstruct similitude present new content. A famous painting by Hans Holbein the Younger (c. 1497–1543), *The Ambassadors* (1533), displays power, wealth, glory, and knowledge from the front, but the lateral gaze reveals, in the unusual and distorted object at the foot of the two dignitaries, the contours of a skull. To the viewer who knows how to take the right point of view, in this case the point of view of Christian faith, anamorphosis unveils a hidden reality, the instability of the world and the necessity of abandoning vainglory. Such is the moral lesson of anamorphosis which forces one to admit that reality must be interpreted and that what appears proper is exactly that which is deceiving. In his *Sermon de carême* [*Lent Sermon*], Bossuet uses the figure of anamorphosis when he compares certain paintings, the meaning undecipherable at first sight, to “a certain natural image of the world and its hidden justice, that we can only acknowledge by looking from a certain point of view that faith reveals to us.”



Hans Holbein the Younger, *The French Ambassadors* (1533). National Gallery, London, Great Britain.

A Hallucinatory Technique

Most optical manipulations are presented as hallucinatory techniques, or devices for escaping reality. Their hidden rationality sets off a defensive reaction and constitutes a challenge to skepticism and dreams of dismemberment.³³ This reaction signifies that amusement is possible at the site where monsters and anxieties once prowled, like a child who plays at frightening himself. Like Perseus decapitating Medusa, the ingenious man evades being spellbound by employing lateral vision, through which one

can make sense of chaos. Although these refracted glances are comprehensible through the laws of reflection, shifted and blurry, these constructions generate no less anxiety and vertigo because the gaze is nonetheless still subject to enchantment by incoherent forms; seduction, based on strangeness, unhinges familiarity and preserves ambiguity. The spectator's ambiguous pleasure, caught between the fantastic and the logical, comes from a lingering doubt, and perhaps a secret desire, that the magic be real. Lurking inside the desire to delude one also finds a desire to be deluded.

Above all, the space broken by anamorphosis is, before being rectified, the space of the schizophrenic. A threat stems from the fact that at any moment the spectator can tip the scales on the side of reason or on the side of fantasy, on the side of knowledge of optical phenomena or on the side of unbridled illusion. The rationalist project overtakes its goal and is reversed: deceived here, disabused there, the spectator is ensnared by the manipulator and never feels safeguarded from illusion. If the secret and the illusion are too easily discovered, achieved through a mere turn of cleverness or aesthetic feat, the game loses its resiliency and causes frustration. Moreover, if an illusion reveals its key and is to still maintain its fascination, it should hint at another, deeper secret layer, like a false-bottomed drawer. Holbein's painting reveals the value of such phenomena: once the anamorphosis is decoded, the spectator contemplates death, not only the death of traditional, moralizing representations of a skull in a mirror, but insecurity, misunderstanding, and dissonance. Worse than the fear of the final end is the process of decomposition, vertigo, and anxiety. The perception of dissolving illusion establishes a being's negative intuition. Try as he might to justify himself by putting forward a moral alibi, the painter offers his spectator the impious angle of a theatrical artifice, and his indirectness undermines the moral rectitude of the representation. Thus Baltrusaitis correctly labeled these games born from an optical perversion as "depraved."

Mannerist sensitivity, ceding to the overtures of a sparkling imagination and playing on the distortion or the perversion of forms, is certainly conscious that beyond a lesson on the vanities and on the deception of the real, it brings to light an intimate and deviant experience for the one who systematically chooses to abandon himself to the arbitrary, who, at the risk of drowning himself in subtleties or of being engulfed by his dream, delights in his capacities of invention. The artist who engenders new meaning by twisting images and words sees the world through a prismatic mirror, in which mirages of analogy become more attractive than what is real.

Among scientists, there is a certain exultation in mastering the laws of reflection by producing artificial images, just as the artist struggles against a rational hardness through metaphor or anamorphosis. Daniello Barbaro (1514–1570) perfected a camera obscura in 1559, and Cardano imagined a device that made it possible to project landscapes and animals painted on a plate of glass. This optical research culminated in the scientific explosion of the seventeenth century. Famous treatises on catoptrics such as *Perspective avec la raison des ombres et des miroirs* (1614) by the exiled engineer Salomon de Caus (1576–1626) or *Perspective curieuse* by Jean-François Nicéron (1613–1646) offered “productions so admirable or rather effects so prodigious” that they rivaled magic and, with the multiplication of mirrors, made “an army appear there where only one man might be, or a long row of columns and a well-ordered edifice, by placing a single column across from the mirror.”³⁴ The German Jesuit Athanasius Kircher (1601–1680), in his *Physiologia* (1669), described the functioning of the magic lantern and invented a sort of “metamorphosis machine” in which a man looking at himself in the mirror sees a row of bull’s heads—or deer’s heads or donkeys’ heads—instead of his own face. The slightly inclined mirror is placed on an axis where the reflections of the human face and of bizarre animals painted on an octagonal wheel converge. The

creator of this dream machine wrote, "From nothing a complete image is born."³⁵ In the same vein, transposed to the literary narrative, lies the "temple of laziness" anonymously invented in 1667 and described as a "cave decorated with large, crystal mirrors cut into different sides." All sorts of fantastic images decorate the walls of the cave and are reflected there. Through the prisms, the fragmented images are randomly juxtaposed, so that one can simultaneously see "a bit of landscape, a small part of a château, the face of a beautiful lady, the wings of a cupid or the ruins of an old palace—all in the mirror."³⁶ Man voluntarily sacrifices the rational to taste "the confusion of dreams."

Hallucinatory techniques were therefore used to serve magic and mark an evolution from a scientific and curious conception of catoptrics to its agreeable and worldly utilization. The deceptive effects of mirrors were sought to stimulate dulled imaginations. With reduced production costs and better distribution, Saint-Gobain mirrors took up residence in galleries, alcoves, and hideaways, on ceilings and on doors; placed across from windows, they opened up oblique and mysterious perspectives, camouflaging passageways. "Mistresses of sweet impostures" that "sweetly amuse the imagination," according to Mademoiselle de Scudéry, mirrors enlivened the walls. The vertigo and impression of emptiness brought about by the mirror's ubiquity was no longer considered troubling, these labyrinths creating a space of marvel.

Court society resembled Psyche transported into a palace of mirrors: in order to take pleasure in her happiness, Psyche must allow herself to delight in a universe of enchantments and metamorphoses without seeking to pierce their mystery, otherwise she will discover only empty simulacra. According to Starobinski, "there is a correlation between a moment of society and an aesthetic climate."³⁷ If the seventeenth century relished the *cabinets de glaces*, it was because by magnifying splendor, their symmetry offered the court the brilliant symbol of its power and the joys of a collective narcissism. But as twentieth-century philosopher

Gaston Bachelard elegantly put it, “symmetry is a mediocre source of dreams.” Rococo art, with its scrolls, its decorative excess, and its profusion of mirrors, aims less for the symbolic prestige of authority than for the reality of luxury, pleasure, or the image of pleasure, and the stimulation of the senses. For an aristocracy dispossessed of its political functions and partying with abandon in the *fêtes galantes*—the costumed parties of young men and women illustrated by Jean Antoine Watteau (1684–1721), the fictive series of corridors simulated by the reflection of mirrors offered up a theater of illusions that disguised—behind a proliferation of images—the loss of power, the emptiness, and, all too soon, death.³⁸

The Libertine Mirror

The value that a libertine society eager for pleasure put on agreeable taste and sensation is well known. Pleasure must incessantly be renewed and excited by new impressions. In the eighteenth century, the effects of mirrors, from which surprises and seductions are born, become the indispensable element of all settings for games of love. For the architect Nicolas Le Camus de Mézières (1721–1789), it was the boudoir that constituted the temple of pleasure, “the sojourn of sensual delight.” He devoted more than twenty pages of his *Génie de l’architecture* (1780) to the arrangement of mirrors in these spaces.³⁹ The boudoir must be an octagonal or circular space of variety and sensuality, where mirrors alternate with solid walls to leave the eye spaces of rest and to create soothing perspectives. Behind the meticulous description of the perfect house, Le Camus pursued his quest for a way of life that combined the serenity of the soul and the gratification of the senses. The use of mirrors reinforces both because in hedonistic self-contemplation “the soul finds delight in itself.” So all that frustrates this intention must be carefully avoided: boredom, monotony, worry, and fatigue always lurk near pleasure. When they are too numerous or badly positioned,

Mirror Fragments

The novelist Nicolas-Edme Restif (1734–1806), known as Rétif de Bretonne, relates that at the age of two, since no one was in a hurry to dress him in the morning, he was often left—much to his dismay and fury—stark naked. At such times his sister brought him a mirror to show him his grimaces. He grabbed the mirror and tried to break it in rage: “The cracks made me even uglier and in the fragments that multiplied objects, I believed I’d found a world behind the mirror. This phenomenon stopped my tears and I felt my first astonishment, my first admiration, my first reflection.”¹ This episode would find its place in a Lacanian scenario: the development of consciousness of the mirror image is integrated in the progress of symbolic activity. For the child who anticipates his unity by the mediation of the mirror, the kaleidoscopic fragments of the broken mirror reveal a protean self, with infinite virtualities. The unordinary world behind the mirror becomes the prism of the imagination and the dream.

As it so happens, however, this dynamic function of reflection is held in check. The image sets into motion too many affects, and the mirror, instead of anticipating unity, breaks into pieces. As a powerful vehicle of the imagination, it is also an agent of dissociation and illusion that threatens the integrity of the self. If romantic sublimation and mastery of games of anamorphosis

provide an inkling of otherness without harm, a confrontation with one's double can also lead the subject, a narcissistic or sadistic spectator of himself, to the edge of delirium.

The mirror is not a neutral, equitable, passive witness. It attacks and betrays its subject when it is not held up lovingly. Psychoanalysts express this phenomenon as follows: if the first mirror, that is to say the mother's gaze, did not respond, the mirror becomes a threatening object that one does not dare to look at, like the "the baby afraid of his mother's face, putting aside his own needs."² This deficiency or primordial frustration obscures all mirrors and distorts the face-to-face encounter. The mirror image becomes a source of fear and anxiety.³ Sometimes, through defensive reaction, the image is overestimated and feeds a narcissistic impulse that nourishes grandiose dreams but fears the gaze of others. Sometimes it becomes a terrifying and aggressive image and loses its symbolic status, to such an extent that it emancipates itself and takes on the attributes of the real in order to persecute the subject. At still other times, refusing all fantastical projection, it disintegrates or disappears. The mirror of dream and of doubt, the mirror of madness, and the empty mirror of insignificance all open the door to monsters, and the fragile bridge linking the inner and exterior worlds is thus broken.

Reflection and Identity

A Fragile Image

Man's relationship with his reflection is conflicted. Forced to let his image enter the mirror, he is revealed—visible, naked, vulnerable, subject to the sight of himself as others see him. He has to control his face, adjust his behavior, hide his secrets. Whether he embraces or rejects this image, he exposes himself to the anguish of being misperceived. Furthermore, the reflection is fragile,

ephemeral, and inconsistent—a mere weakening of consciousness or the cruelty of a sideways glance might cause it to lose its familiar conformity. Worse yet, by revealing the image of the body to consciousness, the mirror becomes a screen for many imaginary projections and identifications. “One no longer belongs to oneself, what a frightening thought,” exclaims the protagonist of Pär Lagerkvist’s 1944 novel, *The Dwarf*, after consenting to have his portrait made.⁴ Something from inside becomes fixed and is lost in the image that anyone can capture.

Of all the faces we come across, our own is the one that we know the least. Contemporary psychologists have emphasized the constantly changing nature of the self image; their studies have allowed them to measure the degree of imprecision normal adult subjects can have with regard to knowledge of their appearance, and this despite the large amount of information—photography and video footage—available to them. Memorization remains vague and incomplete, threatened by emotions and subject to all sorts of pathologies. And this was even more the case in other eras, in times when mirrors were rare, small, and dark. Margaret of Valois (1553–1615, also known as Queen Margot), citing the soldier and chronicler Pierre de Bourdeille (c. 1540–1614), reported that the old Madame de Rendan, having given up her mirror upon the death of her husband, “met her face by chance in someone else’s mirror and asked who that woman was.”⁵ Even before being subjected to any disturbance, the mirror image resists all appropriation and maintains a bit of an odd status.

An “image of the body that might be assimilable to a type of instantaneous photography of objective reality” does not exist either; only vague and subjective approximations. The surrealist writer Pierre Mabilie (1904–1952), author of *Mirror of the Marvelous*, said that the first time he went to Paris, he was panic-stricken amid the mirror games created by the department stores and hotels. “Still today, I am disconcerted before the tri-partite mirrors of tailors.”⁶

Recent psychological studies have sought to delineate the margin of interpretation each of us has for our own image.⁷ In a first group of experiments, individuals were shown artificial distortions of both their mirror image and the mirror image of another person. Subjects of these studies found it easier to articulate the changes in their neighbor's mirror image than in their own. Next, adolescents were invited to look at their reflections in distorting mirrors, and it was noted that only those who felt at ease and secure in their bodies could come to terms with the distortion. These teenagers viewed the hands, nose, face, and shoulders as the most troubling sites of distortion.

A second set of experiments was done with photographs. Adults were presented with truncated images of themselves—seen from the back or sometimes below the neck and the experiment showed how difficult it was for them to identify themselves: thirty-seven percent of the subjects recognized themselves only if their heads were visible, and schizophrenics displayed even greater imprecision in their judgment. Personality disorders appear to give rise to serious deficiencies in the ability to recognize one's mirror image. For some, their image even ceased to appear in the mirror. Such reactions indicate how labored, unsettled, and susceptible to regression an individual's hold on consciousness of his own reflection can be.

No one looks at his mirror image with indifference. Who can admit that this double at the back of the mirror, more or less seductive despite endless touch-ups, is skilled at representing him? "A beautiful woman, looking at herself in the mirror, might believe that she is only that," the philosopher Simone Weil wrote, "but an ugly woman knows that she is not only that." The image we have of our body is neither a reproduction of our anatomical reality nor the product of our social being, but a fluctuating projection, an elaborated concept congealed in the fraction of a moment. "What I want, in short," said Roland Barthes, writing about photographs,

is that my (mobile) image, buffeted among a thousand shifting photographs, altering with situation and age, should always coincide with my (profound) “self”; but it is the contrary that must be said: “myself” never coincides with my image; for it is the image which is heavy, motionless, stubborn (which is why society sustains it), and “myself” which is light, divided, dispersed.⁸

This reflection invested by society with the power of identification is only a hurtful caricature, a sort of crude packaging of the self, an intolerable obstacle to the omnipotent liberty of consciousness: “The very idea that there is an exteriorized image of myself terrifies me.”⁹

Variations on the Theme of the “Same” Thing

To contemplate one’s image is to come up against one’s limits, to see time work its destruction, to fear painful or disturbing evidence that the subject shelters itself from—his biological and mortal reality. Any mirror is a mirror of vanity and any self-portrait leads to an *automortrait* [self-death portrait], according to critic Philippe Lejeune’s clever expression.¹⁰ As both upholder and destroyer of an ideal self, the reflection, unfit for its mission, either cracks or dismisses itself.

In literary history, the Shakespearean hero inaugurates this subjective and disquieting use of the mirror, which captures an unhappy conscience in a negative state. It is at the moment of his forced abdication that King Richard II looks back at himself, trying to recall what he was and no longer is. When the abdication is complete, he demands a mirror from his servant: “Give me that glass, and therein will I read.”¹¹ The clear mirror of the world has lost its intelligibility and the king’s specular encounter increases the fracturing because the king doesn’t recognize himself in the smooth surface: “No deeper wrinkles yet? Hath sorrow struck so many blows upon this face of mine, And made no deeper wounds? O, flatt’ring glass, Like to my followers in prosperity,